DESIGN SYSTEMS • ENTERPRISE SAAS • PRODUCT UI

Designing Decisions That Scale

Building a scalable design system for enterprise SaaS — a system for making product decisions **consistently**, **intentionally**, and **at scale**.

ROLE
UI/UX Designer
Product Designer

FOCUS
Design Systems
Enterprise SaaS
Product UI

TOOLS
Figma
Prototyping
Design System

Design once. Define the rule. Scale with confidence.

A system for making product decisions consistently, intentionally, and at scale.

Design System
Aa
Typography
Components
Enterprise Dashboard
This Month
Revenue
$24.8M
↑ 12.5%
Users
12,845
↑ 8.2%
Conversion
3.42%
↑ 16.7%
Active Now
256
↑ 5.4%
Performance Overview
Top Products
Product A 48%
Product B 28%
Product C 16%
Others 8%

01 CONTEXT & CHALLENGE

The Problem We Were Solving

As enterprise SaaS products grow, visual inconsistency rarely comes from one major mistake. It accumulates through hundreds of small decisions.

Seven Core Problems

— Inconsistent UI patterns across different product areas making the experience feel fragmented
— Repeated design decisions — the same problems solved differently each time by different teams
— No shared design language between designers and developers
— Typography and spacing applied arbitrarily, not systematically
— Color usage without semantic meaning or consistent application
— Components built from scratch each sprint rather than reused from a shared library
— No scalable foundation — every new feature required rediscovering basic design rules

Individually, these decisions may seem insignificant. At scale, they create a product that becomes increasingly difficult to maintain and evolve.

The Challenge

The goal was to establish a shared design foundation that could support an enterprise SaaS product without turning the system into an overly rigid collection of rules. The system needed to make everyday design decisions: more consistent, more predictable, and easier to scale.

The Design Question

Instead of asking *"How should this screen look?"* — I reframed the problem as *"What rules should determine how future screens are designed?"* That shift became the foundation of the entire project.

Objective

Create a scalable design system that:

- ✓ Establishes a consistent visual language
- ✓ Reduces repeated design decisions
- ✓ Supports dense enterprise interfaces
- ✓ Provides clear rules without restricting creativity
- ✓ Translates foundations into practical product decisions

CORE PRINCIPLE
Design the decision once. Make it reusable everywhere

02 DESIGN APPROACH

How We Approached the System

The system was approached as a hierarchy of decisions rather than a collection of isolated UI assets. The process moved through four levels.

Phase 01
Understand
Identify recurring visual and structural decisions across the product.

Phase 02
Define
Establish principles for hierarchy, meaning, spacing, structure, shape, and depth.

Phase 03
Systemize
Translate those decisions into reusable foundations and semantic rules.

Phase 04
Apply
Test the system against product scenarios to validate the foundations worked together.

Four Principles

These principles ensured the design system is a scalable system of decisions — not just a collection of tokens and components.

01
Consistency
Repeated decisions should produce predictable outcomes.
- ✓ Same rules, same results
- ✓ Predictable across products
- ✓ Reduces visual inconsistency

02
Meaning
Design tokens should communicate intent, not simply store values.
- ✓ Colors have purpose
- ✓ Spacing conveys hierarchy
- ✓ Components communicate role

03
Flexibility
Constraints without forcing every interface into the same composition.
- ✓ Enough freedom to adapt
- ✓ Multiple layouts, one structure
- ✓ Supports different use cases

04
Scalability
New product experiences can use the same foundations without recreating the visual language.
- ✓ Built for growth
- ✓ Easy to extend
- ✓ Future-ready foundation

KEY STATEMENT
We are not designing screens. We are designing the rules that screens follow.

03 SYSTEM ARCHITECTURE

Four Layers of Decision

The system is built on a four-layer architecture that flows from raw values to product-ready decisions — each layer inheriting from the one below.

01 · PRIMITIVES
Raw values
Color scales, spacing values, typography values, radius values, elevation values.
"What values exist?"

→

02 · BRAND
Product identity
Connects primitives to identity through Primary · Secondary · Accent — evolves without restructuring the foundation.
"What represents our brand?"

→

03 · SEMANTIC
Product meaning
Translates raw values into meaning — text, surface, border, icon, action, feedback.
"What does it mean?"

→

04 · PRODUCT
Real product UI
Foundations → Semantic Decisions → Patterns → Product UI.
"How does it look in UI?"

Example — Action Token
Blue → Action / Primary → Primary Button

Example — Feedback Token
Green → Feedback / Success → Success State

System Architecture Insight: The architecture separates the what (primitive values) from the why (semantic meaning) and the where (product context). Swap the brand palette globally by changing only the primitive layer — semantic and product layers inherit the update automatically.

SYSTEM ARCHITECTURE INSIGHT
Primitives provide the vocabulary. Semantic tokens provide the meaning. Product UI provides the context.

04 FOUNDATIONS

Creating the visual language

The foundation layer defines the core visual decisions used throughout the system. Six foundations were established.

Color
Color → Meaning

Typography
Typography → Hierarchy

Spacing
Spacing → Rhythm

Grid
Grid → Structure

Radius
Radius → Shape

Elevation
Elevation → Depth

04.1 *Color as a System of Meaning*

Color was structured to do more than establish visual identity. The system separates raw color values from their product meaning.

The System, Explained

● **Primitive layer**
Raw palette values — the complete set of colors available in the system. Blue 50 through Blue 950. Green, Amber, Red, Neutral. No meaning attached.

● **Brand layer**
Brand-specific mapping from primitives. Blue 500 → Brand Primary. Green 500 → Brand Success. This layer owns the brand's color identity

● **Semantic layer**
Intent is assigned. Brand Primary → Action. Brand Success → Feedback/Success. The color now carries a purpose any part of the product can reference.

● **Product UI**
Context-specific tokens for components. Action → Primary Button. Feedback/Success → Success Badge. The token is fully resolved for where it will be used.

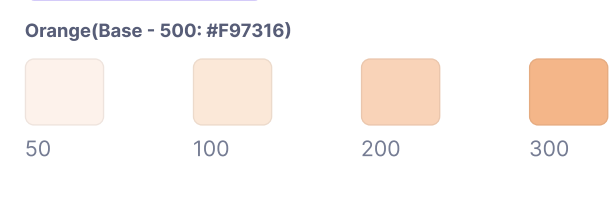
From Hue to Purpose

EXAMPLE 01
Blue (Primitive) → Action / Primary (Semantic) → Primary Action (Product UI)

EXAMPLE 02
Green (Primitive) → Feedback / Success (Semantic) → Success State (Product UI)

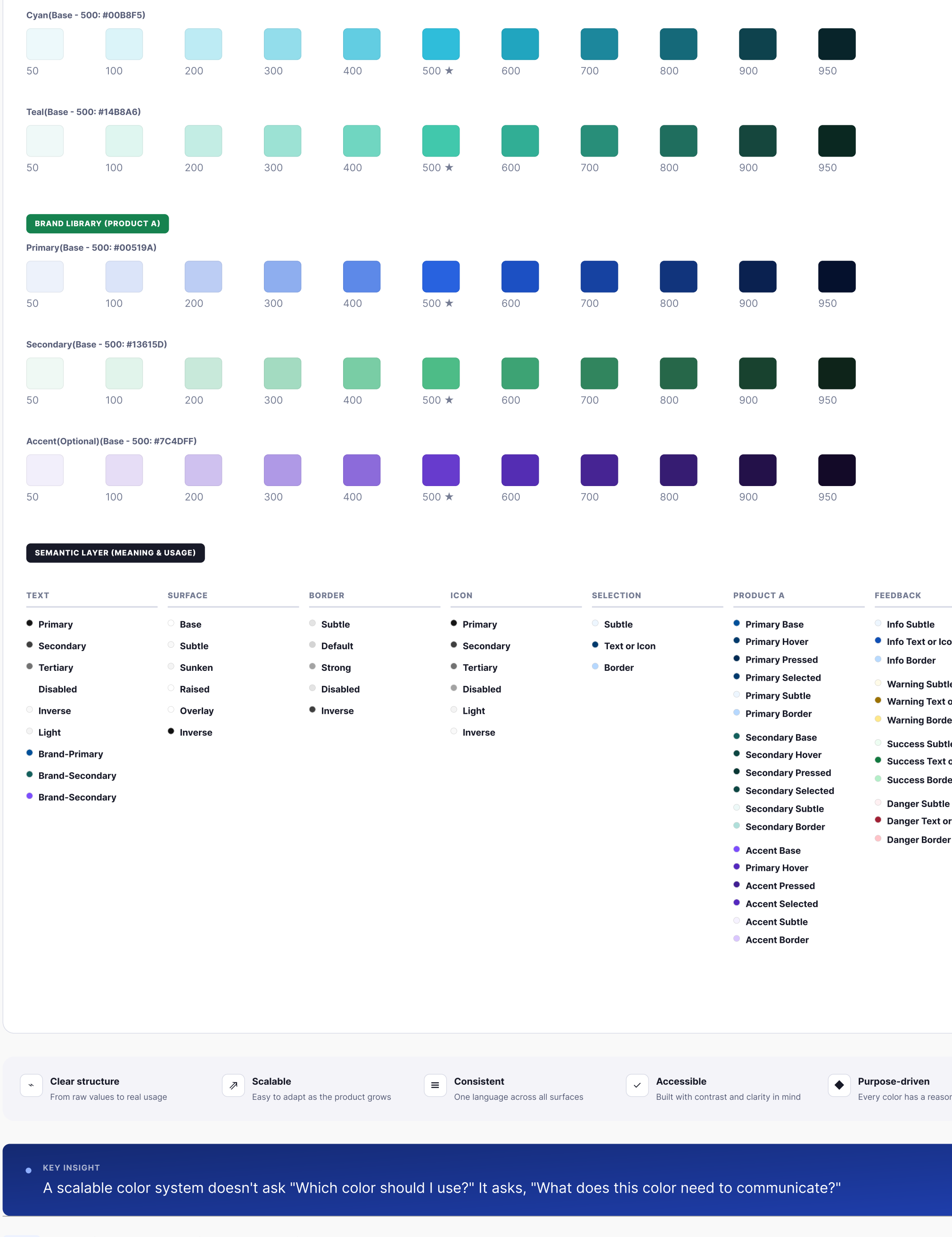
Why This Matters

If the underlying brand color changes, semantic roles can inherit the change without requiring every component to be manually redesigned.



When color is semantic, you can swap the entire brand palette by changing just the primitive and brand layers. Every component inherits the change automatically — no manual updates across the product.

Color System at a Glance


PRIMITIVE / NEUTRAL (BASE:#2F80ED - 500)
0
50
100
200
300
400
Base
600
700
800
900
950
PRIMITIVE / CORE
Blue(Base - 500: #2F80ED)
Green(Base - 500: #22B45F)
Yellow(Base - 500: #E6B100)
PRIMITIVE / EXTENDED
Orange(Base - 500: #F97316)
Purple(Base - 500: #7C4DFF)
Cyan(Base - 500: #00B8F5)
Teal(Base - 500: #14B8A6)
BRAND LIBRARY (PRODUCT A)
Primary(Base - 500: #00519A)
Secondary(Base - 500: #13615D)
Accent(Optional)(Base - 500: #7C4DFF)
50
100
200
300
400
500 ★
600
700
800
900
950

SEMANTIC LAYER (MEANING & USAGE)

TEXT
- ● Primary
- ● Secondary
- ● Tertiary
- Disabled
- Inverse
- Light
- ● Brand-Primary
- ● Brand-Secondary
- ● Brand-Secondary

SURFACE
- Base
- Subtle
- Sunken
- Raised
- Overlay
- ● Inverse

BORDER
- Subtle
- Default
- ● Strong
- Disabled
- ● Inverse

ICON
- ● Primary
- ● Secondary
- ● Tertiary
- ● Disabled
- Light
- Inverse

SELECTION
- Subtle
- ● Text or Icon
- ● Border

PRODUCT A
- ● Primary Base
- ● Primary Hover
- ● Primary Pressed
- ● Primary Selected
- Primary Subtle
- ● Primary Border
- ● Secondary Base
- ● Secondary Hover
- ● Secondary Pressed
- ● Secondary Selected
- Secondary Subtle
- ● Secondary Border
- ● Accent Base
- ● Primary Hover
- ● Accent Pressed
- ● Accent Selected
- Accent Subtle
- ● Accent Border

FEEDBACK
- Info Subtle
- ● Info Text or Icon
- ● Info Border
- Warning Subtle
- ● Warning Text or Icon
- ● Warning Border
- Success Subtle
- ● Success Text or Icon
- ● Success Border
- Danger Subtle
- ● Danger Text or Icon
- ● Danger Border

Clear structure
From raw values to real usage

Scalable
Easy to adapt as the product grows

Consistent
One language across all surfaces

Accessible
Built with contrast and clarity in mind

Purpose-driven
Every color has a reason to exist

KEY INSIGHT
A scalable color system doesn't ask "Which color should I use?" It asks, "What does this color need to communicate?"

04.2 *Creating a Semantic Typography System*

Typography was designed as more than a collection of font sizes. Rather than asking *"Which font size should I use?"* the system provides a contextual answer: *"What type of content am I designing?"*

Aa	Aa	Aa	Aa
Regular 400	Medium 500	Semibold 600	Bold 700

Typeface: Inter · Type scale: 11 · 12 · 13 · 14 · 16 · 18 · 20 · 24 · 28 · 32 · 40px

01 - Line Height Scale

Every font size across the 14 semantic categories below resolves to one of these controlled line-height values — keeping vertical rhythm predictable regardless of context.

FONT SIZE	LINE HEIGHT	RATIO
11px	16px	1.45×
12px	18px	1.50×
13px	20px	1.54×
14px	22px	1.57×
16px	24px	1.50×
18px	28px	1.56×
20px	28px	1.40×
24px	32px	1.33×
28px	36px	1.29×
32px	40px	1.25×
40px	48px	1.20×

02 — Letter Spacing Scale

Values mapped to specific product contexts — Page, Section, Card, Table, Menu, Helper, Button, Input, KPI, System Message, Modal, Profile, Searchbar, Dropdown.

FONT SIZE	LETTER SPACING	USAGE
11px	+2%	Extra small helper & metadata text
12px	+1%	Caption, meta, badge text
13px	0%	Helper, status, label text
14px	0%	Body, input, table cell text
16px	0%	Description, input value text
18px	−0.25%	Card & section sub-headings
20px	−0.25%	Sub-titles, modal titles
24px	−0.5%	Section & KPI headings
28px	−1%	Page titles
32px	−1.5%	Large KPI values
40px	−2%	Display titles

14 Semantic Typography Contexts

Every text style maps to a specific product context. No arbitrary sizes — every decision has a reason and a role

WHY SEMANTIC TYPOGRAPHY?
Product Context → Semantic Text Style → Size + Weight + Line Height + Letter Spacing → Consistent Product UI. This makes typography predictable, reusable and easier to scale.

01 Page Typography

PAGE	
Display Title B	40/48
Title B	28/36
Sub-title SB	20/28
Description R	16/24
Breadcrumb M	13/20
Status M	13/20
Meta R	12/18

02 Section Typography

SECTION HEADER		SECTION CONTENT		SECTION NAVIGATION		STATUS & BADGE		HELPER & ACTION	
Title XL SB	24/32	Description R	14/22	Label M	14/22	Status M	13/20	Helper R	13/20
Title SB	20/28	Caption R	12/18	Breadcrumb M	13/20	Badge or Meta M	12/18	Action M	14/22
Title SB	18/28								
Title SB	16/24								

03 Card Typography

CARD HEADER		CARD CONTENT		CARD METADATA		CARD STATUS		CARD ACTIONS	
Title SB	18/28	Body R	14/20	Meta R	12/18	Status M	13/20	Action	13/20
Title SB	16/24	Caption R	12/18	Helper R	12/18	Badges SB	12/18	Footer	12/18
Title SB	14/20								

04 Table Typography

TABLE HEADER		COLUMN HEADER		TABLE CONTENT		TABLE STATUS		TABLE METADATA	
Table Title	18/28	Column Header	13/20	Cell Text Primary	14/22	Cell Status	13/20	Cell Meta	12/18
Table Description	14/22	Column Helper	12/18	Cell Text Secondary	12/18	Cell Badge	12/18	Cell Helper	12/18
				Cell Numeric	14/22				

TABLE FOOTER	
Footer Text	12/18

05 Menu Typography

PRIMARY NAVIGATION		SECONDARY NAVIGATION		MENU CONTENT		MENU STATUS		MENU FOOTER	
Menu Group Title	12/18	Submenu Item	13/20	Menu Description	12/18	Menu Badge	12/18	Menu Footer	12/18
Menu Item	14/20	Submenu Item Active	13/20	Menu Shortcut	12/18	Menu Counter	12/18		
Menu Item Active	14/20								
Menu Item Disabled	14/20								

06 Helper Typography

PRIMARY HELPER		INTERACTIVE HELPER		VALIDATION HELPER		METADATA HELPER	
Helper Text L	13/20	Hint Text	13/20	Success Helper	13/20	Character Counter	12/18
Helper Text M	12/18	Instruction Text	13/18	Warning Helper	13/20	Field Metadata	12/18
Helper Text S	11/16			Error Helper	13/20		
				Info Helper	13/20		

07 Button Typography

BUTTON SIZES	
XL	18/28
L	16/24
M	14/22
S	12/18
ES	11/16

08 Input Typography

INPUT HEADER		INPUT CONTENT		INPUT SUPPORT		INPUT METADATA	
Field Label L	14/20	Input Value L	16/24	Helper Text	13/20	Prefix or Suffix	14/22
Field Label M	13/20	Input Value M	14/22	Validation Message	13/20	Optional Text	12/18
Field Label	14/20	Placeholder	16/24	Character Counter	12/18		

09 KPI Typography

KPI VALUE		KPI CONTENT		KPI TREND		KPI METADATA	
KPI Value XL	40/48	KPI Label L	14/20	Trend Value	13/20	KPI Target	12/18
KPI Value L	32/40	KPI Label S	12/16	Trend Label	12/18	KPI Period	12/18
KPI Value M	24/32	KPI Description	13/20			KPI Status	12/18
KPI Value S	20/28					KPI Footnote	11/16

10 System Message Typography

MESSAGE HEADER		MESSAGE CONTENT		MESSAGE ACTION		MESSAGE METADATA	
Message Title L	18/28	Message Body L	14/22	Message Action	14/20	Message Timestamp	12/18
Message Title M	16/24	Message Body M	12/18	Message Link	14/20	Message Source	12/18
Message Title S	14/22					Message Reference	12/18
						Message Helper	12/18

11 Modal Typography

MODAL HEADER		MODAL CONTENT		MODAL ACTIONS		MODAL METADATA	
Modal Title XL	24/32	Modal Body L	14/22	Primary Action	14/22	Helper Text	13/20
Modal Title L	20/28	Modal Body M	13/18	Secondary Action	14/22	Caption	12/18
Modal Title M	16/24			Inline Link	14/22	Reference ID	12/18
Modal Subtitle	14/22						

12 Profile Typography

PROFILE HEADER		PROFILE IDENTITY		PROFILE DETAILS		PROFILE STATUS		PROFILE METADATA	
Profile Name XL	24/32	Role or Designation	14/20	Primary Information	14/22	Status Label	13/20	Bio or Description	14/22
Profile Name L	20/28	Department or Team	13/20	Secondary Information	13/20	Profile Badge	12/20	Metadata	12/18
Profile Name M	16/24							Reference ID	12/18

13 Searchbar Typography

SEARCH INPUT		SEARCH SUGGESTIONS		SEARCH HISTORY		SEARCH METADATA		SEARCH FEEDBACK	
Search Query	16/24	Suggestion Title	14/22	Recent Search	14/22	Result Count	12/18	Empty State Message	14/22
Placeholder	16/24	Suggestion Description	13/20	Recent Search Meta	12/18	Keyboard Shortcut	12/18	Search Hint	13/20
Prefix or Suffix	14/22	Search Category	12/18						

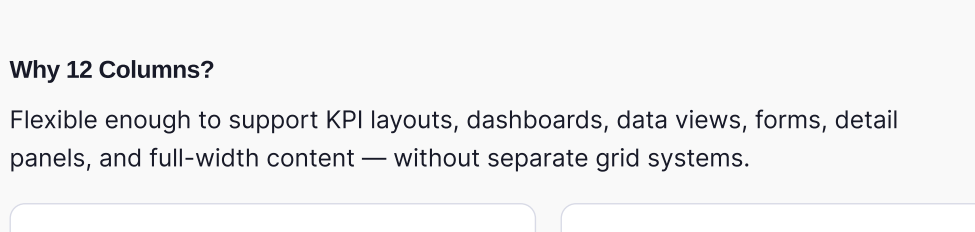
14 Dropdown Typography

DROPDOWN FIELD		DROPDOWN OPTIONS		OPTION GROUPS		DROPDOWN METADATA		DROPDOWN FOOTER	
Dropdown Label	16/24	Option Title	14/22	Group Header	12/18	Option Badge	12/18	Footer Action	14/22
Selected Value	16/24	Selected Option	14/22			Option Status	13/20	Helper Text	13/20
Field Label	14/22	Option Description	13/20			Shortcut	12/18	Empty State	14/22

TYPOGRAPHY PRINCIPLE
Typography is not about aesthetics. It is about communication hierarchy. Every text style answers one question: what does the reader need to understand first, second, and third?

04.3 *The Spacing Scale*

Twelve steps. Five categories. One rule: spacing communicates meaning — hierarchy, grouping, focus, flow, and balance.
Scale: 0 · 2 · 4 · 8 · 12 · 16 · 20 · 24 · 32 · 40 · 48 · 64px.



2–4px
Micro Spacing
Used for fine-grained adjustments within components. Icon-to-text gap, badge padding, tag spacing. Invisible at a glance but critical for polish.

8–12px
Compact Spacing
Internal spacing within components. Padding inside buttons, inputs, and cards. Controls density and tap target size.

16–24px
Standard Spacing
Between components in a group or section. Stack spacing, form field gaps, list item separation. Organizes content into scannable chunks.

32–48px
Section Spacing
Between major page sections. Separates visual groups so the eye can recognize transitions between areas of the product.

64px
Structural Spacing
Page margins, header areas, full-page section breaks. Provides breathing room at the outermost level and anchors the page's visual rhythm.

Spacing vs Grid — What's the Difference?

Spacing controls the distance between elements within a component or group — the gap between a label and an input, or the padding inside a card. Grid controls the macro structure of the page — how many columns, how wide the gutters, how the layout responds to different screen sizes. In practice: spacing answers "how far apart are these two things?" Grid answers "where on the page does this element sit?"

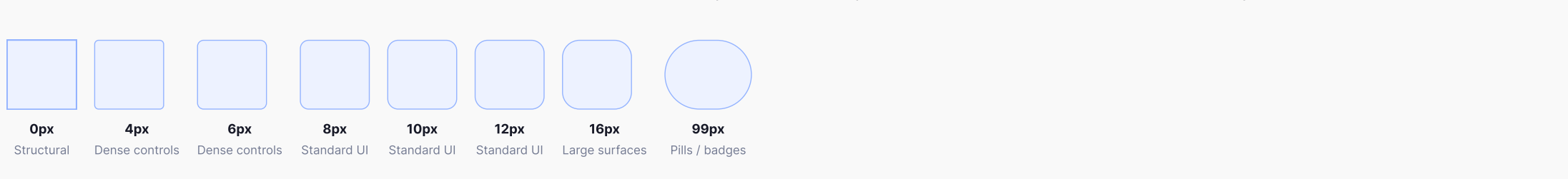
Spacing as Communication

Close spacing signals relationship — these elements belong together. Wide spacing signals separation — these are distinct ideas. Consistent spacing lets the layout communicate structure without relying on borders, dividers, or background colors. When spacing is arbitrary, the page feels assembled. When spacing is systematic, it feels designed.

KEY INSIGHT
The spacing scale is not just a set of values — it is a constraint system. When designers can only choose from 12 values instead of any pixel value, decisions are faster, more consistent, and easier to maintain across the product.

04.4 *Creating Structure Before Layout*

The grid establishes the structural relationship between navigation and product content. A 1440px container divides into 256px Sidebar + 1184px Body — the body uses 24px padding, a 12-column grid, and 24px gutters.



Why 12 Columns?

Flexible enough to support KPI layouts, dashboards, data views, forms, detail panels, and full-width content — without separate grid systems.

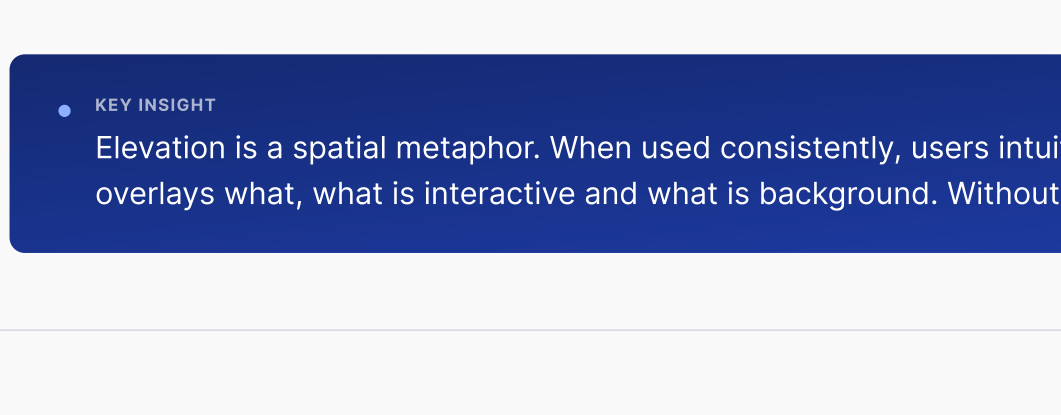
12	4+4+4	8+4	6+6
Full width	Three sections	Main + sidebar	Two halves

LAYER	PROPERTY	VALUE
Application	Width	1440px
Sidebar	Width	256px
Body	Width	1184px
Body	Padding	24px
Body Grid	Columns	12
Body Grid	Margin	0px
Body Grid	Gutter	24px

KEY INSIGHT
Grid and spacing are complementary, not redundant. The grid controls the macro structure — where elements sit in the layout. Spacing controls the micro structure — how elements relate within that structure. Both must be systematic for the product to feel cohesive.

04.5 *Border Radius System*

Radius defines how surfaces, controls, cards, and interactive elements are shaped across the product. Scale: 0 · 4 · 6 · 8 · 10 · 12 · 16 · 99px.

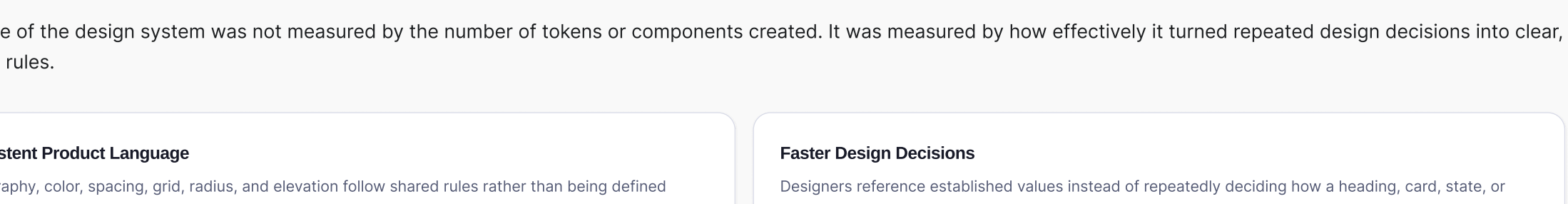


KEY INSIGHT
Border radius is one of the most subtle signals in a design system — and one of the easiest to get inconsistent. Without a scale, every designer makes a slightly different choice. With a scale, the product maintains a single, legible visual language across every component.

04.6 *Elevation & Shadow System*

Elevation defines how surfaces relate to one another in space, using five controlled levels. Shadow color: Neutral 950 · X: 0px · Spread: 0px.

TOKEN	Y	BLUR	OPACITY
None	0px	0px	0%
XS	1px	2px	8%
SM	2px	6px	10%
MD	4px	12px	12%
LG	8px	24px	14%



KEY INSIGHT
Elevation is a spatial metaphor. When used consistently, users intuitively understand the z-axis of the UI — what is in front of what, what overlays what, what is interactive and what is background. Without a system, these spatial signals become noise.

05 FROM FOUNDATIONS TO PRODUCT

Foundations → Design Decisions → Product UI

The foundations became valuable when they started influencing product decisions — hierarchy, density, layout, states, interaction.

Foundations
Typography · Color · Spacing · Grid · Radius · Elevation

Design Decisions
Hierarchy · Density · Layout · States · Interaction

Product UI
Real product experiences, built with the system

The goal was not to build every possible SaaS component. The goal was to demonstrate that the same underlying rules could guide real product composition.

KEY INSIGHT
A design system is not made of components — it is made of decisions that create consistency. Foundations → Decisions → Real Product Outcomes.

06 IMPACT & LEARNINGS

From visual consistency to design efficiency

The value of the design system was not measured by the number of tokens or components created. It was measured by how effectively it turned repeated design decisions into clear, reusable rules.

Consistent Product Language
Typography, color, spacing, grid, radius, and elevation follow shared rules rather than being defined independently.

Faster Design Decisions
Designers reference established values instead of repeatedly deciding how a heading, card, state, or layout should behave.

Controlled Visual Complexity
The system provides flexibility while intentionally limiting arbitrary choices.

Scalable Foundation
New product experiences can be composed from the same foundations without recreating the visual language from scratch.

What I Learned

01 **A Design System Is a Decision System**
A design system is more than a collection of tokens and components. Its real value comes from how effectively it guides decisions.
Tokens define the boundaries. Principles define how those boundaries are used.

02 **Consistency Doesn't Mean Uniformity**
A scalable system shouldn't force every screen to look identical. The goal is to establish consistent rules while allowing contextual variation.

03 **Fewer Rules Can Create More Scalability**
A large collection of highly specific rules can become difficult to maintain. A focused foundation creates a more flexible system, centered around Typography · Color · Spacing · Grid · Radius · Elevation.

04 **Foundations Need Contextual Validation**
A token can look correct in isolation and behave differently in a real interface. The dashboard application helped validate whether the foundations worked together under realistic information density.

The Bigger Shift

Designing Screens
Solving individual problems
Repeating decisions

→

Designing Foundations
Defining reusable decisions
Applying them across product UI

FINAL LEARNING
The designer's role shifts from creating individual interfaces to creating the rules that make future interfaces easier to design well.

CLOSING

Designing the system behind the product

The project started with a need for greater consistency across a complex SaaS environment. It evolved into something more fundamental: a system for making product decisions consistently, intentionally, and at scale.

Typography → Hierarchy · Color → Meaning · Spacing → Rhythm · Grid → Structure · Radius → Shape · Elevation → Depth

"Together, these foundations created a shared visual language that could support future product decisions without requiring the visual system to be reinvented each time."